

RAJEEV GUPTA

**IN HARMONY**
Trainees taking part in a boot camp at the police band school in Bhopal

MP POLICE

# BAND OF BROTHERS

**By Rahul Noronha**

The lively notes of brass and percussion instruments echoed through the Upper Lake in Bhopal, as the Madhya Pradesh Police Band performed for the locals and tourists thronging the popular spot on a Sunday evening in late January. This performance marked a new era for police bands in the state.

A month prior, just three days after being sworn in as chief minister, Mohan Yadav had made an unusual request during a visit to the police headquarters (PHQ) in Bhopal. Even as the top cops were busy reeling out crime figures and details of initiatives being taken to curtail them, Yadav directed the state police chief, Sudhir Saxena, to ensure every district had its own police band—scaling up from just five currently to 55.

What's the idea behind this move? "Bands help the police become more people-friendly," explains Saxena. "Their performance promotes enthusiasm towards the uniformed services, making them an attractive employment avenue." But transforming this vision into reality won't be a song and dance routine. Police bands have been categorised into three grades—A, B and C. The first will have a strength of 36 musicians each and will be stationed in Bhopal, Indore, Jabalpur, Gwalior and Ujjain. Grade B bands, with 26 musicians, will be deputed in police ranges while the remaining districts will get Grade C bands with a strength of 16 musicians each.

The Special Armed Force (SAF), the police paramilitary under which the bands are placed, has invited applications from among its ranks, and the response so far has been positive. Top officials attribute it to the opportunity of getting stationed in district headquarters. Recruits are also being sought from among the specialist trade constables while the PHQ has asked the government for permission to recruit an additional 800 jawans for the bands. Currently, 330 trainees are taking part in a 90-day boot camp at the state's lone police band school in Bhopal. Senior members have been sent to boost their skills at the Border Security Force (BSF)'s centre in Bengaluru, who will then serve as master trainers. The PHQ is also in talks with the army's music school in Pachmarhi to conduct courses.

**MADHYA PRADESH WILL SOON HAVE A POLICE BAND IN EACH DISTRICT, IN A BID TO MAKE THE FORCE MORE PEOPLE-FRIENDLY**

So, what will these police bands do day-to-day? They will continue to play on ceremonial occasions and parades. But, now, citizens in small towns will also be treated to smartly dressed police musicians performing in public places. "Traditionally, bands have performed not just at ceremonial functions, but have been inspirational and motivational too," says Col. H.K. Dube (retd), formerly associated with the Pachmarhi music school.

But the move has also invited scepticism. "The government's priority should be its core function—maintaining law and order," says Congress spokesperson K.K. Mishra, "not promoting music." But ensuring harmony is also a part of the law enforcers' brief, and a band at least won't bulldoze that cause. ■